The Challenge Story

Getting a two-hundred-year-old private bank to change a regulated process. Why it answers the question, the one piece you are missing, and the move you made that you are badly underselling.

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1 Does it answer the question? Yes — and better than you think

You asked whether this really answers it. Let me be precise about what the question wants, then score you against it.

What the question asks for	Have it?	Comment
A real obstacle, not an inconvenience	**Yes**	Institutional resistance in a regulated firm is a proper obstacle. Much better than a tight deadline.
A diagnosis — *why* it was hard	**Partly**	You know it was hard. You have not yet articulated *why the resistance was reasonable*, which is section 4 and is the single biggest upgrade available.
A specific action that was yours	**Yes**	The sandbox proof-of-concept. You are badly underselling it — section 5.
A hard, quantifiable result	**No**	**This is the gap.** Section 6.
A reflection that defends a trade-off	**Not yet**	You made one. You just have not named it. Section 7.

You have three of five, and the two missing pieces are both recoverable. **The story is strong. What you are doing right now is telling it as a project with an obstacle in it, rather than as a challenge.**

The difference matters. In a project story, the thing you built is the subject. In a challenge story, **the obstacle is the subject** and the thing you built is just the weapon you used against it. Reorder it that way and the same facts score much higher.

2 What kind of challenge this actually is

Here is the first thing to get right, and it is good news.

> Your challenge was **not technical**. Building the thing was the easy half. The challenge was **institutional** — getting a very old, very careful firm to change a process that carries regulatory weight.

That is a more impressive challenge than a technical one, for three reasons:

- **Technical problems have answers.** Institutional ones have people, incentives and legitimate competing interests. Nobody in a bank is impressed that a student can build something. They are impressed that a student got something *adopted*.
- **It is the actual job.** In Client Solutions you will spend your career trying to get things through legal, compliance, risk and operations. This is a miniature of that.
- **Almost nobody else will have one.** Most candidates' challenge answers are a hard exam, a tight deadline, or a group project. Yours involves changing how a 200-year-old institution does something.

3 Four things you are underselling

1

What a DDQ actually is, and why automating it is frightening

You have never said this out loud and it is the thing that gives the story stakes.

A due diligence questionnaire is not internal paperwork. **It is the document an institutional client uses to decide whether to allocate, and to justify that decision to their own board later.** The answers in it are effectively representations by the firm about how it operates, invests and controls risk.

So getting a DDQ answer wrong is not an inconvenience. It is a regulatory and reputational problem, and the error can surface years afterwards. **That is why people were nervous, and saying so turns their resistance from an obstacle into a reasonable position you had to engineer around.**

2

The firm's age is a structural fact, not colour

Pictet was founded in **1805**. Say the year rather than "220 years old" — it is more precise and it lands harder.

But do not use it as a joke about dinosaurs. Use it as an explanation: a private partnership whose entire product is being trusted with other people's money across generations is *correctly* conservative about changing a client-facing process. The caution is the business model working, not a failure of imagination.

3

You did not work alone, and that is a strength

You mentioned "me and another senior analyst" almost in passing. Keep that in. Two things it buys you: it shows you could persuade at least one experienced person before you tried to persuade a committee, and it stops the answer reading as a lone intern crusading against the firm, which is not a flattering picture.

If the senior analyst gave you cover, credibility or access you would not have had, say so plainly.

4

The existing process tells you the size of the problem

"Excel and a lot of email threads" is doing more work than you think. It means there was no single source of truth, no version control, and answers scattered across inboxes. For a document that is effectively a set of firm representations, that is a genuine control weakness, not just an annoyance.

From what you have told me before: roughly **400 lines of questions across 20 teams.** Use that. It is the number that shows why email could not cope.

4 The framing that will lift this answer most

The instinct when telling this story is to cast the firm as the villain — old, slow, resistant. **Resist that completely.** It is the same mistake as calling your housemates lazy, and the fix is the same.

WEAK FRAMING

"It was a 220-year-old firm so they were quite resistant to change and I had to convince them to adopt AI."

What it sounds like: an intern who thinks everyone older than him is slow. Also implies you believe the objections were stupid, which makes your eventual "success" sound like you wore people down.

STRONG FRAMING

"The resistance was reasonable, which was the actual difficulty. A DDQ is what a client uses to justify an allocation to their board, so the answers are effectively firm representations. Nobody was going to let an intern put AI near that on the strength of an argument."

What it sounds like: someone who understood the other side before trying to move it. Which is the whole skill.

THE GENERAL RULE, AND IT IS THE SECOND TIME IT HAS COME UP

In the teamwork story you reframed your housemates from lazy to rationally free-riding. Here you reframe the firm from resistant to correctly cautious. **Never let the other people in your story be the problem.** Explaining why their position made sense is what makes your action look like judgement rather than stubbornness.

5 The move you made, named properly

You described this almost apologetically — "we sort of started by just proving the concept on our own." That is the best thing in the story and it has a name.

You could not win an argument about something nobody could picture. **So you stopped arguing and built the thing in a place where it could not do any damage, then let the artefact make the argument for you.**

Break down why the sandbox specifically was the right call, because each part answers a different objection:

What the sandbox did	The objection it defused
Made it concrete	"I can't picture what you're proposing." Now they could look at it.
Contained the risk to zero	"You can't put client-facing content near an untested tool." You were not asking them to. Nothing could escape the environment.
Cost the firm nothing to consider	"We don't have resource for this." You and one analyst had already done the expensive part.
Moved the question	From *"should we do this?"*, which invites a no, to *"here is what it does — what would have to be true for us to use it?"*, which invites a list. **A list is progress. A no is not.**

That last row is the sophisticated one. You converted an open-ended permission question, which any cautious institution answers with "no" by default, into a specific conditions question. That is a genuine technique and you should say it.

6 The gap: you have no result

THIS IS THE THING THAT WILL COST YOU MARKS

You told me what you built and what was difficult. **You did not tell me what happened.** A challenge answer without an outcome reads as a story about effort, and effort is not an achievement. I do not know how yours ended, so here are the three possible endings and how to tell each one honestly.

ENDING A

It was adopted and is in use

The strongest by far. Lead with it. "It's the process they use now" is a complete answer to "so what?"

Then give one number: time per DDQ before and after, number of questionnaires run through it, or the number of people who no longer have to chase email threads.

ENDING B

It got approval in principle, or was partly adopted, or you handed it over

Still strong, and very common for an intern. Do not dress it up as more than it was — say exactly where it got to.

"By the time I left it had been approved for [scope] and was being rolled out to [whatever]" is an honest and perfectly good result. The achievement is clearing the institutional hurdle, and you can say so: "the hard part wasn't the build, it was getting to yes."

ENDING C

It did not get adopted

This is still a legitimate answer, and told well it can be more credible than a tidy success. But it only works if the reflection carries it.

The shape: "It didn't get over the line while I was there, and I think I know why — [specific reason, e.g. we proved it worked before we'd understood who actually owned the decision]. What I'd do differently is [specific]." A candidate who can diagnose their own failure precisely is more impressive than one with a neat win and no insight.

What you must *not* do is imply success you did not have. If a follow-up catches that, everything else you said becomes suspect.

GO AND ESTABLISH THIS BEFORE YOU RECORD

Check your own notes, emails or handover document. Three questions: **How far did it actually get? Is anyone using it now? And do you have any before-and-after measure at all** — hours per DDQ, number of email threads eliminated, turnaround time? Even a rough one you can honestly caveat ("it took roughly a day rather than most of a week") is worth far more than nothing.

7 Your reflection — three candidates

The framework wants a defended trade-off plus a real-world lesson. You made a trade-off. Pick whichever of these is actually true.

REFLECTION A — THE ARTEFACT OVER THE ARGUMENT · RECOMMENDED

"Looking back, the thing I got right was accidental. I'd assumed the hard part was building it and the easy part would be explaining it. It was completely the other way round. What actually worked was that we stopped trying to win the argument and built something people could look at in an environment where it couldn't do any harm. That changed the question from 'should we allow this' to 'what would have to be true for us to use it' — and the second one you can actually answer. In a firm that old, with something that client-facing, I don't think any amount of arguing would have got there."

REFLECTION B — THE NARROWED AMBITION · USE ONLY IF THIS IS WHAT HAPPENED

"The trade-off I'd defend is that we stopped proposing the full version. The thing we could have built was more ambitious than the thing that could get approved, and I think we'd have got nothing if we'd held out for it. So we scoped it down to the part that kept a human reviewing and signing off everything client-facing, and took the smaller win. It isn't the version I'd have designed in a vacuum, but it's the version that exists."

REFLECTION C — UNDERSTANDING THE OBJECTION FIRST

"What I'd take from it is that I spent the first stretch trying to persuade people and not much time working out what they were actually worried about. Once I understood that a DDQ answer is effectively a representation the firm is making to a client, the objection stopped looking like resistance and started looking like a design constraint. The thing that moved it wasn't a better pitch, it was building something that took their concern seriously in the first place."

ONE QUESTION THAT DECIDES WHICH REFLECTION YOU USE

Did your solution keep a human reviewing and approving everything before it went to a client? It almost certainly did, and if so, *say it explicitly* — because that is the single design decision that makes AI acceptable in a regulated client-facing process. "It never sent anything; it prepared, and a person approved" is the sentence that would have unlocked the whole conversation internally, and it will land the same way in an interview.

8 The full answer, in STAR-R

About 115 seconds. Brackets are yours to fill. Highlighted phrases are doing specific work.

SITUATION — ~20 SECONDS

This was on my placement at Pictet, which is a Swiss private bank founded in 1805. One of my tasks was to rebuild how we handled due diligence questionnaires. These are the long documents institutional clients send before they allocate — ours ran to around 400 questions and the answers sat with about 20 different teams — and the whole thing was being run on spreadsheets and email threads.

TASK — ~15 SECONDS

The obvious fix was to automate a lot of it with AI. But the real problem wasn't technical. A DDQ is what a client uses to justify an allocation to their own board, so the answers are effectively representations the firm is making. Nobody was going to let an intern put an AI tool anywhere near that on the strength of an argument — and honestly, they were right not to.

ACTION — ~45 SECONDS

So I worked on it with one of the senior analysts, and we stopped trying to win the argument. We built a working version in a sandboxed environment instead — somewhere it physically couldn't touch anything live, so we weren't asking anyone to take a risk while we tested whether the idea even worked.

[If true: And we deliberately kept a person reviewing and approving everything before it went anywhere near a client. The tool prepared the answers, it never sent them.]

Then we showed people the thing rather than describing it. And that changed the question. It went from "should we allow this", which an institution like that answers with no by default, to "right, what would have to be true for us to actually use it" — which is a list, and a list is something you can work through.

RESULT — ~15 SECONDS

[YOUR REAL OUTCOME — see section 6. One number if you have one: time per DDQ before and after, how far it got, whether it is in use.]

REFLECTION — ~20 SECONDS

What I got wrong at the start was assuming the build was the hard part and explaining it would be easy. It was completely the other way round. And the thing that moved it wasn't a better pitch — it was building something that took their actual concern seriously, in a place where saying yes cost them nothing. In a firm that old, with a document that client-facing, I don't think any amount of arguing would have got there.

9 Weak version versus strong version

HOW YOU ARE CURRENTLY TELLING IT

"At my internship one of my tasks was to replace the due diligence questionnaire process, which was Excel and email threads."

"The challenge was getting a 220-year-old firm to adopt AI. There were a lot of policy restrictions."

"Me and a senior analyst proved the concept in a sandbox and showed we could speed up the process."

"The hardest part was convincing the team it was doable."

Problems: the firm sounds like the villain, the sandbox sounds incidental, there is no result, and the lesson is missing.

THE SAME FACTS, PROPERLY

"400 questions, 20 teams, run on spreadsheets and email."

"A DDQ is what a client uses to justify an allocation to their board. So the answers are firm representations — and nobody was letting an intern put AI near that on the strength of an argument. They were right."

"So we stopped arguing and built it somewhere it couldn't do any harm."

"That changed the question from 'should we allow this' to 'what would have to be true to use it'. A list, not a no."

"[Result.] And what I got wrong was assuming the build was the hard part."

10 What to cut, and one real warning

Cut	Because
"They were resistant to change"	Makes them the villain and you the hero. Explain the objection instead.
"I convinced them" / "I got buy-in"	Vague and self-congratulatory. Say what specifically changed their mind.
Leading with the tool's name	Name it once if asked or in passing, but the story is about institutional adoption, not about which tool. Lead with the tool and it sounds like a tech demo.
"It was a 220-year-old firm"	Say "founded in 1805". More precise, and it does not sound like a punchline.
"I automated the whole process"	Almost certainly overstated, and one follow-up will find it. Be exact about scope.
Any claim you cannot evidence	Especially the result. An inflated outcome is the one error that contaminates everything else you said.

THE CONFIDENTIALITY POINT — THIS MATTERS PROFESSIONALLY

You are describing an internal process at a former employer, in a recording that will be watched by a competitor firm. Be careful.

Fine to say: that you rebuilt a DDQ process, that it was on spreadsheets and email, the rough scale, that you used a sandboxed environment, that there were policy constraints around client-facing content.

Do not say: client names, specific internal policies, anything about their security or control architecture, or internal system names. If in doubt, describe the *shape* of the constraint rather than its content — "there were restrictions on what could touch client-facing material" rather than the actual rule.

Being visibly careful about this is itself a point in your favour. A candidate who discloses a former employer's internals is a candidate who will disclose yours.

11 The follow-ups

They ask	You say
"What were the policy restrictions?"	Shape, not content. "Broadly, restrictions on what could touch client-facing material and on where data could sit. I'd rather not go into their specifics."
"Isn't it risky to use AI for client documents?"	**Agree with them.** "Yes, if it's drafting unsupervised. That's exactly why it never sent anything — it prepared answers from existing approved material and a person reviewed and signed off everything."
"How much time did it actually save?"	Give your real number or admit you do not have one. "I don't have a clean before-and-after — what I can tell you is [qualitative but specific]." Never invent it.
"Who actually made the decision?"	If you know, say. If you do not, that is itself a lesson worth admitting: "Honestly, working out who actually owned the decision took longer than it should have, and that's the bit I'd do earlier next time."
"What did the senior analyst do versus you?"	Be exact and generous. Vagueness here reads as taking credit.
"Could you do that here?"	Stay modest. "I'd want to understand the controls before assuming anything transfers. The bit I think does transfer is building something small people can look at, rather than asking permission for an idea."

12 Why this is the right challenge for this job

Client Solutions is a seat where you coordinate investment, legal, compliance, risk and operations — **none of whom report to you** — to get something client-ready, against constraints you cannot remove.

Your challenge story is that, in miniature. And notice it is the *same trait* as your house-hunt story: getting an outcome out of people you have no authority over, by reducing what you need from them rather than by pushing harder.

Two independent contexts, one work and one not. That makes it a pattern rather than an anecdote — which is why, if a human asks for a second example in round two, you are in good shape.

THREE THINGS TO DO BEFORE YOU FILM

- **Establish your result.** Section 6. This is the single highest-value thing you can do and it is a search through your own emails.
- **Confirm whether human sign-off was retained.** If yes, it goes in the Action beat and it is the strongest detail in the story.
- **Decide what you will not disclose** about Pictet's internals, before you are on camera rather than during.

What is mine and what is yours. Every event here is yours; I have added no facts. What I have added is framing: the DDQ-as-representation point, the reasonable-resistance reframe, the naming of the sandbox move as converting a permission question into a conditions question, and the confidentiality guidance. Pictet was founded in Geneva in 1805, which is a matter of public record. The 400 questions and 20 teams come from what you told me earlier in our conversation — check them before saying them. Everything in square brackets is something only you can supply, and you should not say any of it unless it is true. One disclosure, since you mentioned the tool by name: I am Claude, made by Anthropic. Name the tool or do not — it makes no difference to the strength of the story, which is about institutional adoption rather than about software.